Good Boys

By Jane Martin

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

ACTOR 1: James, Father of Ethan and Ethan
ACTOR 1: Thomas, Father of Marcus and Marcus

(James is in the park, standing and muttering to himself. He swigs from a flask and moves to a park bench, still talking to himself. We can't discern what he is saying. He sits. Thomas enters quietly, unassumingly. He surveys the park and finds James on the park bench. It is obvious he knows James will be here. He approaches and gestures for James to share the bench. James does, still wrapped up in his flask and internal thoughts)

THOMAS: **(Pg 14)** *(Beat)* Sir, I'm Thomas Thurman, Mr. Erskine. *(James turns his head to look at him, caught between conflicting impulses. He rises to leave, then sits again, then rises again to leave)* Please talk to me, sir.

JAMES: **(Pg 15-16)** *(James turns harshly, obviously distraught)* I don't talk about that, Mr. Thurman. I'm through talking about that. I'm finished with it! *(He starts to go)*

THOMAS: *(Staying calm)* You'd just walk off on me?

JAMES: Dammit! I have to get on the other side of this. I would think you would want to get on the other side of it. There has to be an end to it! *(Again turns to leave)*

THOMAS: I have a picture of your son . . . *(James hesitates)* . . . in the school. *(Thomas holds out a snapshot)*

JAMES: What? *(Shift of energy from angry to broken . . . pause)* When he was alive? *(James takes the picture, looks at it and begins to breakdown)* **(Pg 29)** Is that your son lying on the floor? *(Thomas nods and turns away in grief)*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 2: *Two fathers: each struggling to deal with a deeply disturbing chapter in their lives –*
ACTOR 1: *The school shooting in which both their sons, Marcus and Ethan, died*
ACTOR 2: *One a victim and the other the shooter.*
ACTOR 1: *This selection explores the pressures of modern family life and the breaking points of men and boys.*
ACTOR 2: *And it raises 2 questions:*
ACTOR 1: *1) To what extent are parents responsible for their children's behavior?*
ACTOR 2: *And 2) Is forgiveness an event or a process?*
TOGETHER: *Good Boys by Jane Martin*

THOMAS: **(Pg 17)** When he was alive. *(James does not take the picture)*

JAMES: *(A moment)* You didn't just run across me in the park.

THOMAS: No, sir. I sought you out. **(Pg 19)** I am a pastor, Mr. Erskine. **(Pg 17)** I'm just working on it the best I can. *(A pause)* And, painful as every part of it is, it seems like I feel some better the more I know . . .

JAMES: Well, that would not be my experience. There isn't any more I need to know.

THOMAS: **(Pg 19)** Beg your pardon, but I see here you're drinkin' in the middle of the day. I know something about that. Oh, yes. I notice you cannot bear to hear about that day. There was a long time there . . . a long time . . . it made me physically sick to hear it. We are brothers on that score. *(beat)* **(Pg 33)** I came here to ask you to come and ask forgiveness in my church.

JAMES: **(Pg 35)** Goddamnit!

THOMAS: I would ask that you not take the Lord's name in vain.

JAMES: He was a good boy. You understand that? *(Ticking them off)* Plays well with others. Imaginative, articulate. Liked by teachers. Straight A student until ninth grade. Untrustworthy? On the small stuff. A pain in the ass? Absolutely. I didn't raise a shooter, do you understand that? I do not need to stand up in front of your church and be forgiven. *(Belligerent)* I'll tell you what, Thomas. My son Ethan killed your boy. **(Pg 34)** He shot nine children. Four young women. Two standing as close as I am to you.

FLASHBACK to Ethan and Marcus (altercation at school)

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MARCUS: (Pg 23) *(enters and sees Ethan)* Hey! What are you doin', yo, yellin' stuff when I'm talking to my ladies. Yo, tell you what. Yell some more shit, I'm here to hear it.

ETHAN: Don't be sayin.' You talking about yelling across the lunchroom? Did I want to come and suck it?

MARCUS: I didn't yell it, man, I walked over and ***said*** it to you. You think I'm blind, man? I don't see those signs you hold up at the game? "Don't feed the animals," that shit. Look at you. You embarrass the school man.

ETHAN: *(Furious)* What the hell are you talking about, moron? You're coming over me when you're got up in your artificial, phony-ass, imitation LA "gangsta-drag?"

MARCUS: *(Physically assaulting Ethan – he takes him to the ground)* You know what's on the ground now, sucker?

ETHAN: *(Fighting to get loose, which he does and steps back)* Hey, you touch me. You lay one finger on me, I'll see you in the slammer, asshole . . . *(Marcus throws one punch into Ethan's midsection. Ethan drops to one knee. Marcus grabs him by the hair and lifts him up – they fight)* Get off me!

FLASHBACK to Thomas and James dealing with the boys (lines should overlap)

JAMES: (Pg 6) Ethan!

THOMAS: (Pg 18) [Marcus!]

JAMES: (Pg 6) In the living room!

THOMAS: (Pg 18) Don't walk off on me!

JAMES: (Pg 7) Are you out of your mind? What the hell is the matter with you?

THOMAS: (Pg 18) You will call the boy, apologize.

JAMES: (Pg 7) No it isn't okay . . .

THOMAS: (Pg 18) Did your Lord Jesus ever respond to provocation with violence?

JAMES: (Pg 10) What the hell am I going to say to your mother?

THOMAS: (Pg 18) I told you to walk off from fools . . . Did I not?

JAMES: (Pg 9) Shut up, Ethan . . . your car is gone. Your computer is gone.

PRESENT DAY

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JAMES: **(Pg 35-36)** I'll tell you what, Thomas. If there was a last thing in the world I wanted to do today, I guess I would say this is it. It's the conversation I've spent eight years having with everybody, including myself. But I've stayed here because I thought the least I owed you was a conversation.

THOMAS: And we haven't had it. We're not having it!

JAMES: We've been having it. Because we are two different kinds of people, you can't hear it.

THOMAS: Different kinds, huh? Oh, we're different, that's right. You can't even hear yourself, man. "I don't want to talk about it," Uh-huh, yeah . . . you hidin' behind this, hidin' behind that, an' that's just chicken shit, man.

JAMES: F*** you!

THOMAS: *(Enraged)* You so angry at everybody, who you really angry at?

FLASHBACK to the day of the shooting (Marcus and Ethan) (Pg 31-32)

(We hear 4 gunshots, then Marcus crosses the stage followed by Ethan who has a 45 in his hand)

ETHAN: *(completely amped up and out of control and talking to himself)* **(Pg 5-6)** What, you think I'm an idiot? You think you're awake but, umm, you're not awake. I clicked in that clip, we were all awake like this *(He snaps his fingers several times)* Wow! I felt good. I woke us up. When I opened up. *(Marcus enters, sees James and tries to leave)* **(Pg 31-32)** Stay right there, man. *(Marcus turns and now James has a new mission. To kill Marcus)* Real deal. Drop the books *(he does)* Goes around, comes around, huh?

MARCUS: Thought we got straight? *(Ethan moves in forces Marcus to his knees he circles him as he speaks)*

ETHAN: You'll be dead in sixty seconds. How does that feel? Yeah, you made the list. You beat the piss out of me but you don't get the big picture, man. I am so way beyond that.

MARCUS: My bad, all right? I' sorry, okay? *(Ethan moves forward until the pistol is directly in Marcus' face.)* Don't shoot me in the face!

ETHAN: Really? Now I'm completely crazy and it's all too late. I got SWAT teams up the wazoo, so hey, I don't have time for this. Okay? See you later! *(Ethan shoots Marcus in the face. He then turns and fires 3 more times from a double-handed firing position into the audience.* **(Pg 42)** *His cell phone rings. Ethan pauses, answers the phone and listens, it is*

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obviously his father on the other end) (Softly) It's not your fault. Tell Mom I love her. I'm scared, Dad . . . Gotta go . . . **(Pg 45)** *(Ethan turns the gun on himself and commits suicide)*

PRESENT DAY

JAMES: (Pg 36) You're locked in the cage, Thomas. Driving yourself crazy chasing yourself in circles. You are chasing something that ***does not*** exist. Closure ***does not*** exist.

THOMAS: You got to open the door and walk through it, brother.

JAMES: I don't want to hear your goddamned sermon. Did I invite your Lord down here? If there's some Lord on the premises then he must have sanctioned Ethan, right?

THOMAS: You better shut up, James. You raised your son, man. He didn't just get it from the air. You know the apple don' fall far from the tree. You **know** that.

JAMES: You think I'm angry? What the hell do you think you are? You didn't come down here on the peace and love special, "brother." You came here for payback.

THOMAS: (Pg 38-39) I'm not. . .

JAMES: *(distraught)* My son killed those children and then . . . and then . . . he put the pistol I bought him in his mouth . . . and killed himself.

THOMAS: James, [we're] doing the wrong thing carrying this around. Wrong thing for me and the wrong thing for you.

JAMES: . . . I loved my son. See, I don't think I'm so different from you . . . that anybody, you , anybody could have foreseen what happened. I didn't. His teachers didn't and it's not clear to anybody what the hell was in his head. He didn't warn his friends, he didn't leave a note.

THOMAS: You got it all in your own courtroom, huh? You think as long as you're the prosecutor and defense and judge, you don't have to let anybody else in there. I went to a lot of trouble to find you, man, and all this time we been talkin' you still don't know why?

JAMES: Because it must be harder than anything in this world not to have somebody to blame.

THOMAS: Oh, I have somebody to blame, James. I blame myself. Who do you blame? I want to know was there a way to stop it. Cause if there was, I need forgiveness. You believe in forgiveness, Mr. Erskine?

JAMES: (Pg 27) The truth is . . . I don't know what to say anymore. *(Taps his forehead)* [It's]

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always there. Smashes into my life, and anything I'm doing or feeling seems . . . beside the point. No amount of grieving for him and what he did can ever be enough.

THOMAS: **(Pg 37)** . . . . I used to go over to your house. 3 am, 4 am . . . stand on your walk . . . think about ringing your bell. I been a lot of bad places in my life . . . standing on your lawn in the dark, that was the worst. **(Pg 29)** *(James weeps)* Prayer takes us though moment we would not otherwise survive. We could kneel down here, James.

JAMES: No

THOMAS: We would be heard.

JAMES: No. No, thank you. *(James takes out his wallet, in it he has pictures of Ethan as a young boy. He takes a shuddering breath)* I miss what Ethan was. Ethan as a little kid . . . I miss that. **(Pg 35)** He was a good boy. . . *(switches back to the picture that Thomas brought)* [But] my son killed those children and then he killed himself. . . . listen, I did the best I could . . . **(Pg 40)** I am . . . deeply sorry. *(He reaches out to Thomas)*

THOMAS: *(reaches out to take James hand)* **(Pg 44)** The Lord's here . . . *(They both bow their heads in prayer)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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****NOTE: In the original play, Thomas and Marcus are African American. This cutting eliminates references to race and could be performed by students of any race.***